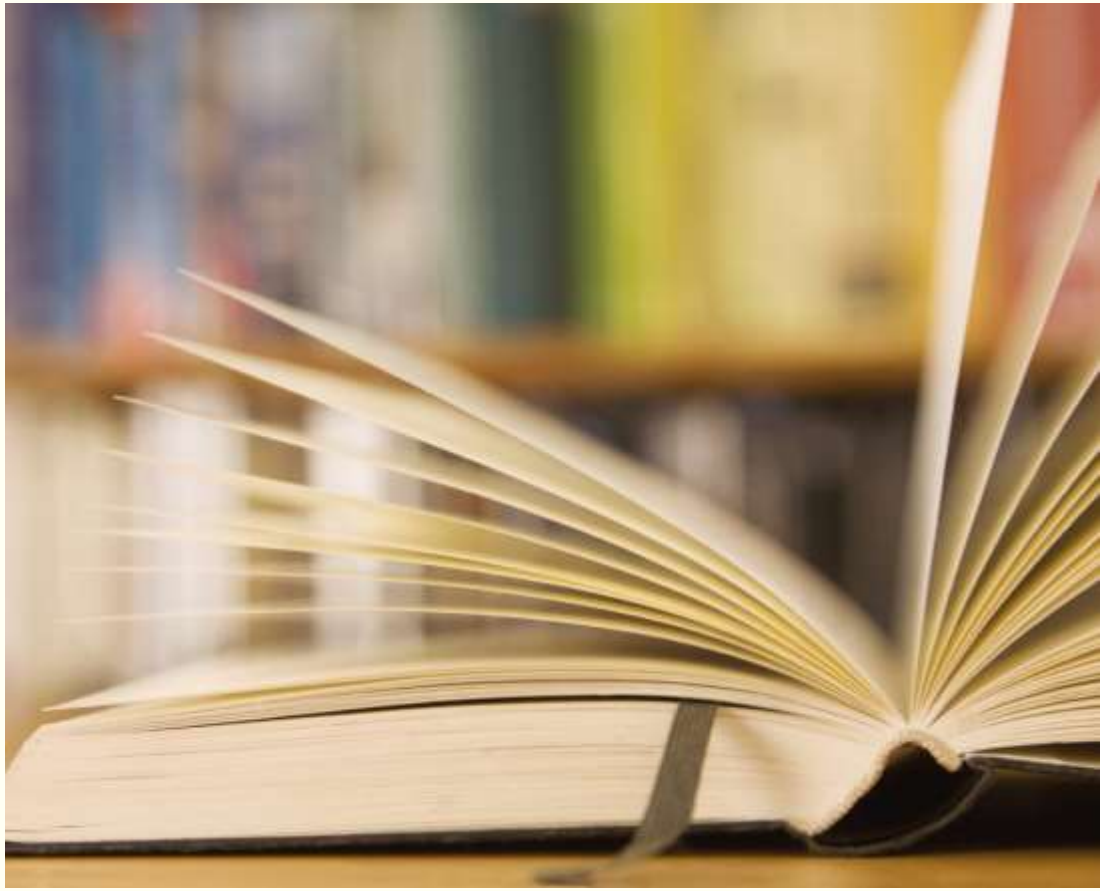
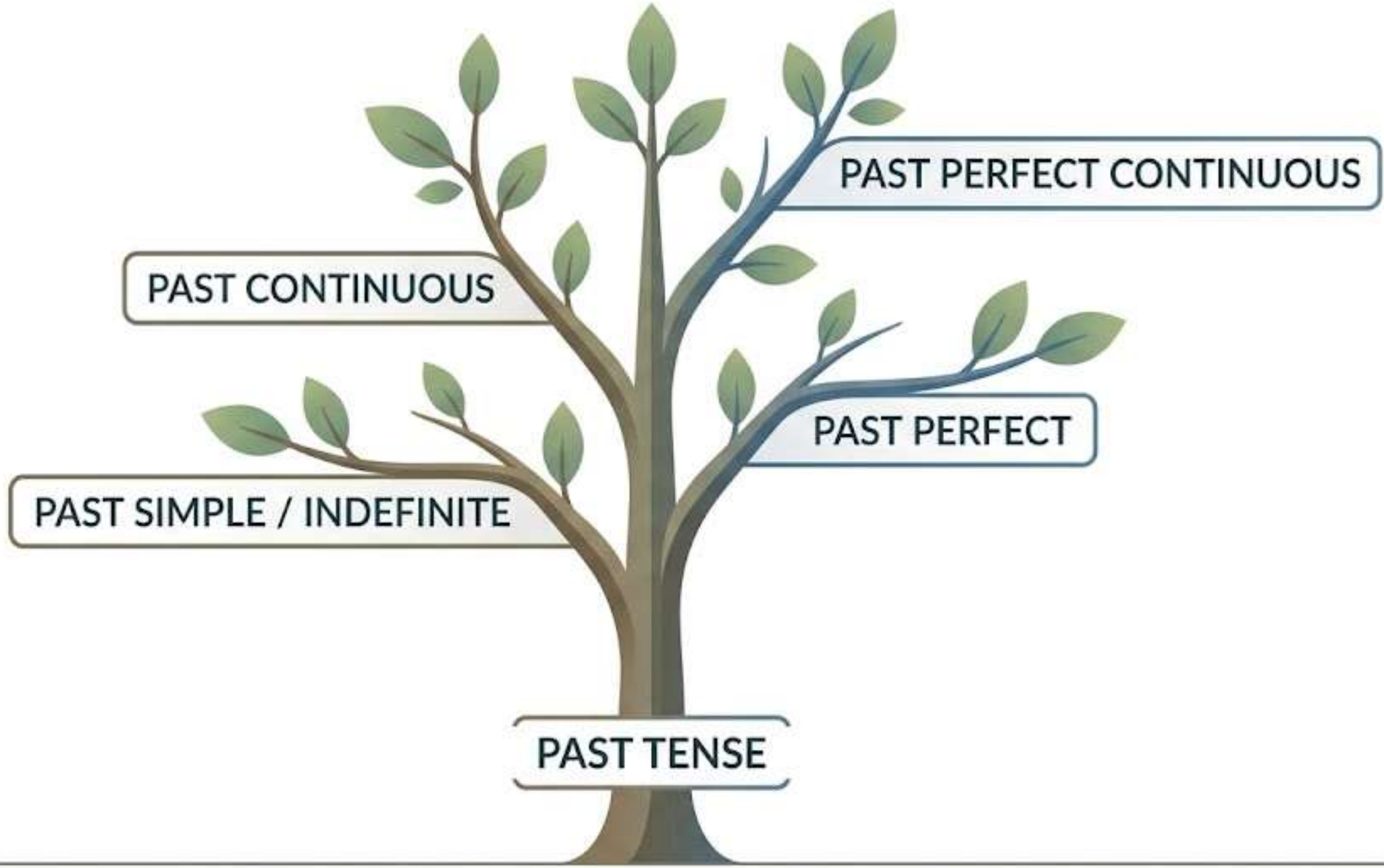
ENG 1011, ENGLISH I

PAST TENSE

SAJJAD HOSSAIN
Faculty, Department of English




PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS
PAST CONTINUOUS
PAST PERFECT
PAST SIMPLE / INDEFINITE
PAST TENSE

PAST SIMPLE/INDEFINITE TENSE

Focus: Past Routines & Discontinued Habits

This tense describes repeated patterns, habits, or routines that occurred over a period in the past but are no longer true.



- I always rode my bike to school during my early childhood.



- We regularly watched classic movies after school when we were teenagers.

KEY POINT: USED TO vs. SIMPLE PAST

While both can show past recurrence, 'USED TO' implies a distinct discontinued state, while Simple Past describes past repeated actions without present status.

(USED TO) He used to paint every weekend. → This habit has ceased.

(SIMPLE PAST) He painted every weekend for five years. → Describes past actions; current state unknown.

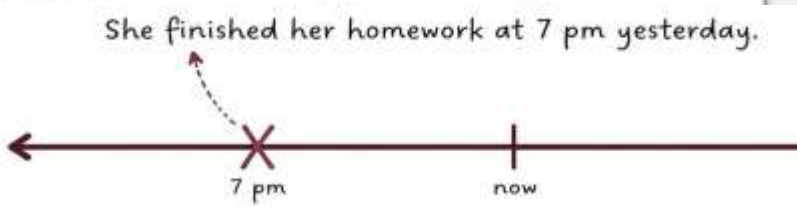
PAST SIMPLE/INDEFINITE TENSE

Focus: Specific, Completed Past Events

This tense describes actions or events that **occurred at a specific, known time in the past** and are now finished.



- I visited my grandmother last week.
- We watched the new movie yesterday.



KEY POINT 2: SIMPLE PAST vs. PRESENT PERFECT (Specific Time)

While both can show past actions, 'SIMPLE PAST' requires a **specific time reference** (e.g., yesterday, last week, in 2020), while 'PRESENT PERFECT' shows general past actions without a specific time.

(SIMPLE PAST) She called me at 7 PM yesterday. → Action was at a specific, known time.

(PRESENT PERFECT) She has called me. → Action happened in the past; time is unknown.

COMMON SPECIFIC TIME INDICATORS (Simple Past)

yesterday last night last week last month last year ago two years ago in 2020 on Monday

PAST CONTINUOUS TENSE

Past Continuous Tense shows an action that was happening at a specific time in the past. It shows that the action was not finished yet.

1. I **was having** breakfast at 8:00 AM.
2. She **was talking** to her friend.

STRUCTURE:

Subject + was / were + verb + ing + (rest)

INTERRUPTION EXAMPLE: Using it when a short action interrupts an ongoing action.

Subject + was/were + verb+ing



He was sleeping...
Past continuous
(Ongoing)

Subject + Past verb



...when the phone rang.
Past simple
(Interrupts)

Subject + was/were + verb+ing



They were walking...
Past continuous
(Ongoing)

Subject + Past verb



...when it started to rain.
Past simple
(Interrupts)

Past Continuous Tense

WHEN

Used for a **short interruption** of an ongoing past action.



- The phone **rang** when I **was studying**.




- He **was driving** when she **called**.

WHILE

Used for **two ongoing actions happening at the same time.**



- I **was studying** while he **was watching** TV. 



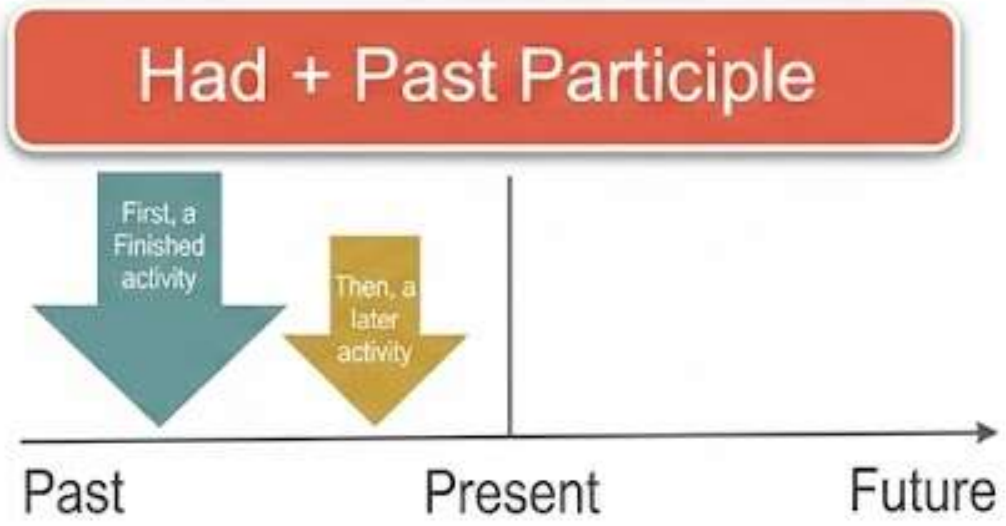
- The teacher **was explaining** while the students **were taking notes** 

PAST CONTINUOUS vs. PAST SIMPLE

Feature	Past Simple (Interruption / Completion)	Past Continuous (Ongoing Action)
Focus	Focuses on the completion of an action.	Focuses on the duration or progress of an action.
Example 1	The doorbell rang.	They were playing football.
Example 2	I read the economics chapter yesterday. (Finished)	I was reading the economics chapter yesterday. (In progress)

PAST PERFECT

Past Perfect Tense is used to show that **one action was finished** before **another action occurred** in the past.





We had parked the car before the heavy rain began.

- The earlier action → **Past Perfect Tense**
- The later action → **Past Simple Tense**

PAST PERFECT TENSE

Shows an Action *Before* Another Past Action.

Earlier Past Action (had+V3) → Later Past Action (V2) → Present

CAUSE OF A PAST STATE

The company **was** (Simple Past) in trouble **because** management **had ignored** (Past Perfect) early market warnings.

Simple Past [Result] + **because** + Past Perfect [Reason]

The thief **had run away** (Earlier Past) **before** the police **came** (Later Past).

Past Perfect [Earlier Action] -> [before] + Simple Past [Later Action]

REALIZATIONS & DISCOVERIES

By the time the professor **arrived** (Later Past), the students **had already completed** (Earlier Past) the mock test.

[by the time / before + Simple Past Action] + Past Perfect Action

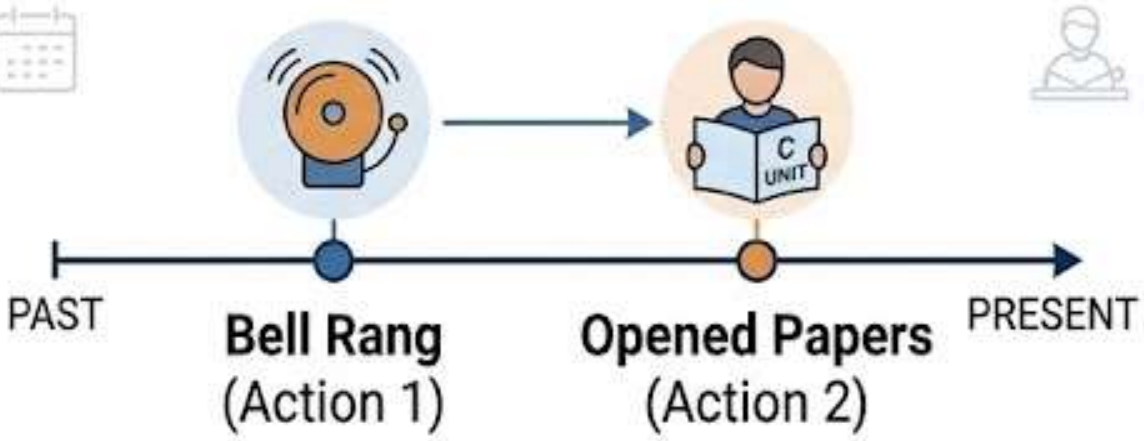
He **realized** he **had left** his calculator at home only **after** the exam **started**.

Earliest Past Action (had+V3) → had left.
Later Past Events (V2) -> realized, started.

Past Simple vs. Past Perfect: Chronology Matters

PAST SIMPLE (SEQUENTIAL EVENTS)

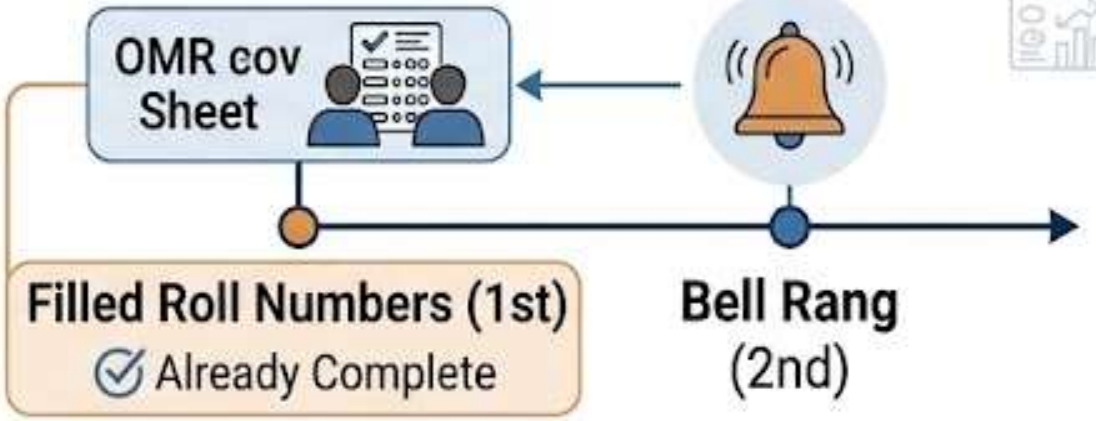
Use **Past Simple** for events that happen in **chronological order** (one after the other).



The bell rang, and the candidates opened their C unit question papers.
(Action 1, then Action 2)

PAST PERFECT (OUT-OF-SEQUENCE EVENTS)

Use **Past Perfect** when you break chronological order to refer back to an earlier action (the "past in the past").

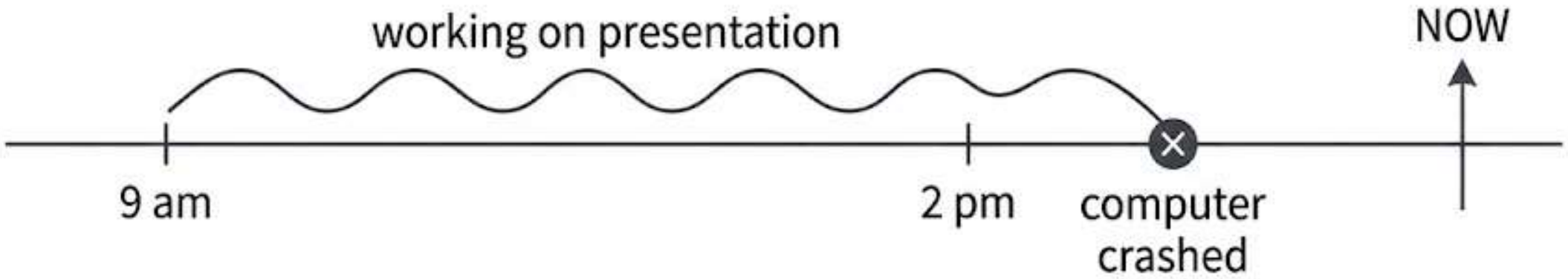


When the bell rang (2nd), the candidates had already filled in their roll numbers on the OMR sheet (1st)...

PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS

Past Perfect Continuous Tense is used to show that an action started in the past and **continued** for some time before another past action happened.

He had been working on the presentation for five hours when the computer crashed.

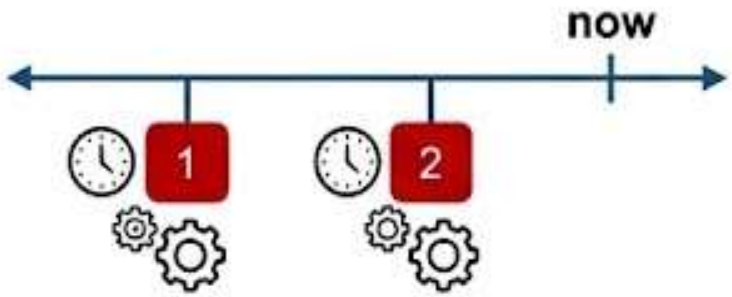


- She **had been typing** the report **for** two hours when her supervisor arrived.
- They **had been rehearsing** the play **since** noon when the power went out.

PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS TENSE

We use Past Perfect Continuous when an **action happened for some time in the past** and **that action caused a result or situation** in the past.

- **Cause (had been + V-ing) → Result (past situation)**



1. She had been baking cookies.
2. The kitchen was a mess.



The **kitchen was a mess** because **she had been baking cookies**.

- They were exhausted because **they had been training for a marathon.**

→ **Cause: They had been training for a marathon.**

→ **Effect**: They were exhausted.

- His hands were blistered because **he had been gardening all afternoon.**

→ **Cause: He had been** gardening all afternoon.

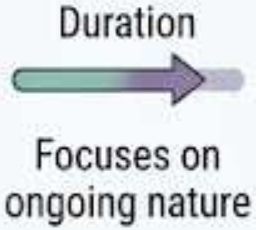
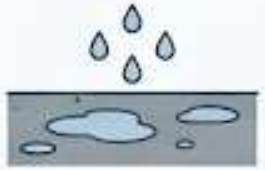
→ **Effect**: His hands were blistered.

- Their flight was delayed because **it had been snowing at the destination.**

→ **Cause**: **It had been snowing** at the destination.

→ **Effect**: Their flight was delayed.

PAST PERFECT VS. PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS

FEATURE	PAST PERFECT (had + Past Participle)	PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS (had been + V-ing)
Focus	Focuses on the ***result*** of an earlier completed action.  Focuses on completed actions	Focuses on the **ongoing nature** of an earlier action. 
Concept	The ground was wet (effect) because it **had rained** (completed cause). 	The ground was wet (effect) because it **had been raining** **(duration cause)**. 
Examples	The room was quiet because the students **had taken** the test. Focuses on condition *after* completion.	The students were stressed because they **had been taking** back-to-back tests. Focuses on condition *due to* duration.

1. PAST SIMPLE (NEGATIVE)

Structure:

SUBJECT + DID NOT (DIDN'T) + BASE VERB

Examples:

- I **DID NOT GO** TO THE LIBRARY YESTERDAY.
- HE **DIDN'T EAT** THE CAKE LAST NIGHT.

2. PAST CONTINUOUS (NEGATIVE)

Structure:

SUBJECT + WAS/WERE NOT + VERB-ING

Examples:

- I **WAS NOT COOKING** DINNER AT 7 PM.
- THEY **WERE NOT LISTENING** TO THE PROFESSOR.

3. PAST PERFECT (NEGATIVE)

Structure:

SUBJECT + HAD NOT (HADN'T) + PAST PARTICIPLE (V3)

Examples:

- I **HAD NOT CLEANED** THE KITCHEN BEFORE SHE ARRIVED.
- SHE **HADN'T VISITED** NEW YORK BEFORE.

4. PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS (NEGATIVE)

Structure:

SUBJECT + HAD NOT BEEN + VERB-ING

Examples:

- I **HAD NOT BEEN WORKING** FOR LONG BEFORE THE POWER WENT OUT.
- THEY **HADN'T BEEN LIVING** THERE FOR A MONTH BEFORE THE RENT WAS DUE.

Practice Exercise

- **Instructions**: Choose the correct past tense (Simple, Continuous, Perfect, or Perfect Continuous)

- By the time the invigilator ___ (announce) the end of the test, I ___ (already/finish) my essay.
- The accounting student ___ (rub) his eyes; he ___ (stare) at the spreadsheets since 6 AM.
- While the committee ___ (discuss) the new university policies, the dean suddenly ___ (walk) in.
- She ___ (not/submit) her application yesterday because the online portal ___ (crash) an hour earlier.
- She _____ (watch) TV when her friend called her.
- They _____ (play) football for two hours before it started raining.
- I _____ (visit) my grandparents last weekend.
- The children _____ (laugh) because they had heard a funny story.

Multiple Choice Practice

- **Instructions**: Select the most appropriate tense to complete each sentence:



- When the final merit list ___ (was / had been) published, the student realized she ___ (secured / had secured) a top position.



- The candidate ___ (struggled / was struggling) with the accounting section while the invigilator ___ (walked / was walking) down the aisle.



- He ___ (did not realize / had not realized) his mistake until he ___ (handed / had handed) in his answer script.



- They ___ (waited / had been waiting) outside the examination hall for forty minutes before the gates finally ___ (opened / had opened).

Written Practice: Find the Errors

- **Instructions**: Identify and correct the tense errors in the following sentences:
- Incorrect: By the time I reached the campus, the admission test already started.

➢ Correction: _____

- Incorrect: She was studying business principles for three months before she took the mock exam.

➢ Correction: _____

- Incorrect: I was reading the instructions on the question paper when the sudden announcement was interrupting me.

➢ Correction: _____

Answer Keys

- **Practice Exercise Answers:**
- announced (Simple) / had already finished (Perfect)
- rubbed (Simple) / had been staring (Perfect Continuous)
- were discussing (Continuous) / walked (Simple)
- did not submit (Simple) / had crashed (Perfect)
- was watching (Continuous)
- had been playing (Perfect continuous)
- Visited (Simple)
- laughed/were laughing (simple/continuous)
- **Select the most appropriate tense:**
- When the final merit list was published, the student realized she had secured a top position
- The candidate was struggling with the accounting section while the invigilator was walking down the aisle
- He did not realize his mistake until he had handed in his answer script
- They had been waiting outside the examination hall for forty minutes before the gates finally opened

Answer Keys

- **Identify and correct the tense errors:**
- Incorrect: By the time I reached the campus, the admission test already started.
- Correction: By the time I reached the campus, the admission test had already started
- Incorrect: She was studying business principles for three months before she took the mock exam.
- Correction: She had been studying business principles for three months before she took the mock exam
- Incorrect: I was reading the instructions on the question paper when the sudden announcement was interrupting me.
- Correction: I was reading the instructions on the question paper when the sudden announcement interrupted me.

ANY QUESTIONS ???